MARCUS AURELIUS

Perfumes

NOT FOR EVERYONE.

THAT'S THE POINT.

COMPANY PORTFOLIO · 2026

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AMMAN, JORDAN

CONTENTS

WHAT IS IN THIS DOCUMENT

This is the full record behind the company: the reasoning, the figures, the two years that produced the first bottle, and what the numbers actually say. The website states the case. This states the evidence.

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THE COMPANY IN ONE PAGE

Marcus Aurelius Perfumes is a luxury niche fragrance house in Amman, Jordan. It develops, produces and sells four original Eau de Parfum compositions, entirely in-house and entirely direct, with no distributor, no retailer and no marketplace anywhere between the bottle and the person who wears it.

4 Original compositions	2 YEARS Of development before the first sale	36 Bottles sold in the first fortnight	93.9% Gross margin at list price

THE GAP IT EXISTS TO FILL

The niche market splits at two extremes: established houses at $300 and above, where the buyer pays for a real composition and for a European company's overheads on top of it, and a budget tier that sells the appearance of niche with cheaper oil and shorter process. There is nothing in between where the buyer pays for the composition and nothing else.

HOW IT REACHES THAT POSITION

By removing the chain. Rent, retail markup and distribution margin are what normally consume the price of a fragrance; a company that carries none of them can put the money into the oil instead. A bottle costs between 3.90 and 5.50 JOD to make, fully loaded, and sells at 70 or 90 JOD. The margin is not extraction, it is what the absence of six intermediaries looks like on a page.

WHAT HAS ACTUALLY BEEN PROVED SO FAR

- Thirty-six bottles sold in fourteen days through a private circle at founder pricing, with **zero** spent on marketing.
- **1,230 JOD** of gross profit from that fortnight, covering 68% of two years of development.
- Seventeen more bottles clears the remaining development cost entirely.
- The sales mix independently confirmed the seasonality the market research predicted: the two fresher compositions took 61% of units, during summer.

WHAT HAS NOT BEEN PROVED

Everything above happened inside a closed circle of friends and family, which is finite and now exhausted. Nothing here demonstrates that a stranger will pay 90 JOD for a fragrance from an unknown Jordanian house, and the public launch is the test of exactly that. The plan in section 17 is built around finding out rather than around assuming.

THE ONE DECISION EVERYTHING ELSE FOLLOWS FROM

Nobody else will ever sell this bottle. Not a perfumery, not a distributor, not a marketplace. Retail, when it comes, will be the company's own rooms. That decision costs volume, costs speed and costs the easiest growth available, and it is the reason every other commitment in this document is possible. Section 09 sets out the argument in full.

Anyone can buy the same oils tomorrow. Nobody can buy two years.

THE BUSINESS IDEA

PROBLEM

The niche perfume market is split between two extremes. At one end sit the original, high-quality niche houses, priced at $300 and above. At the other sit cheap niche-styled brands that cut corners on oil quality in order to compete on price, selling the appearance of niche without the substance of it.

There is no middle ground offering real craftsmanship without exploitation. A buyer who wants a composition that was actually developed rather than copied has to pay for a European house's overheads to get it.

SOLUTION

Marcus Aurelius breaks that binary with exclusive, non-derivative blends, carefully selected oils, and fragrances engineered to be magnetic through composition alone, without relying on banned or synthetic pheromone additives.

The claim that the cheap end cuts corners on oil quality is one this company is in a position to make, because it did the opposite and can show what that cost: two years, more than thirty formulations and 1,800 JOD spent before a single bottle was sold. Section 04 sets out exactly where that went.

UNIQUE VALUE PROPOSITION

This is not a perfume made to please everyone, and it is not meant to be wearable by everyone. That exclusivity is the point: a selective fragrance built for a defined identity, not a mass-market crowd-pleaser.

What cannot be copied quickly is not the formula but the time. Anyone can buy the same oils tomorrow. Nobody can buy two years of iteration, and a serious trial cannot be hurried, because a single one takes forty days to finish.

TARGET CUSTOMERS

People who want distinction, not just a pleasant scent: buyers looking for individuality, a story, a persona, and quiet confidence before they are looking for a smell. In practice this is a buyer who already knows what mass-market fragrance smells like on everyone else, and has decided against it.

A perfume that has to announce itself has already lost the argument.

COMPANY OVERVIEW

Industry

Luxury niche fragrance, Eau de Parfum concentration.

Location

Amman, Jordan. Online-first, with no physical retail location at present.

Stage

Private soft launch complete. Public launch pending final photography.

SERVICES

Design and production of exclusive, limited-batch fragrances, each with its own visual identity and narrative: **Maxima**, **Maximus**, **Romeo di Roma** and **Roma Juliette**. Everything from composition to packaging to the sales channel is held in-house.

WHAT THE COMPANY ACTUALLY DOES

It develops fragrance compositions from raw oils, macerates and bottles them in small batches, designs the identity and packaging around each one, and sells them directly to the customer with no intermediary anywhere in the chain. It is a manufacturer and a retailer at once, deliberately, because the two roles are what most brands give away and what this one keeps.

THE FOUNDING STORY

It began as a coffee-shop conversation between two friends: why does no fragrance carry these particular notes, and why not make one ourselves? There was no brand in mind. There was curiosity, and a rooftop.

2 YEARS	30+	40 DAYS	1,800 JOD
Before a single bottle was sold	Formulations tried and rejected	For one serious trial to finish	Spent before any revenue existed

The manufacturing videos were discouraging: industrial machines the size of rooms, the kind of equipment that makes the whole idea look closed to anyone without a factory. Then came the discovery that the houses actually worth their price still work by dropper, blend by hand, and leave a composition to macerate somewhere naturally cool. Simpler. And far more expensive, because what the machine replaces is time, and doing it by hand means paying that time back.

The first year went on finding a source. When one was found, European and reached through a Swiss intermediary, the first order of oils cost 500 JOD, and the blending was done in drinking glasses.

More than thirty formulations followed. One smelled good but sat oily on the skin. One burned the nose. One was gone by midday. One smelled like everything already on the shelf. A serious trial takes FORTY DAYS: a week frozen, then thirty days in darkness at a steady 16 to 19 degrees. The rooftop provided that for nothing, which is the reason two years was affordable at all.

The second year cost 1,300 JOD: new notes, dyes, better equipment, and alcohol rectified to **100%** where most perfumery, French houses included, works at 96%. A litre of it costs roughly ten times as much.

Specialists advised starting with cheap oils and buying the good ones once the formula worked. **That advice was refused.** The same note from a cheaper source is a different composition made a different way, and it shows in how long it lasts and in how it sits on the nose of someone wearing it all day. A formula proved on cheap oil is a formula proved on the wrong material. A compromise made at the start is not undone later.

THE ACCIDENT THAT PRODUCED THE FIRST BOTTLE

Romeo di Roma came out of a coincidence. Headphones on while his friend slept, a throwaway song playing, and one word in it stuck: *pineapple*. A note the niche houses use often, and one already sitting among the materials. It went in with caramel and vanilla.

He wore it into the street. The compliments that came back were not expected. **Only then did it become a brand.** The two years came first, spent on something intended for nobody but themselves; the company is what happened when other people reacted to it.

> *The rooftop belonged to the friend from that first conversation, who kept him company through most of it, and whose house is the reason the maceration conditions cost nothing. The company itself is built and run by Abdullah Al-Sallal.*

DEVELOPMENT, IN DETAIL

The portfolio claims elsewhere that the cheap end of the niche market cuts corners on oil quality. This section is the evidence that this company did not, and what refusing to cost.

WHERE THE MONEY WENT

RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT, BY YEAR

YEAR	WHAT IT BOUGHT	JOD
Year one	First order of Swiss-brokered niche oils. Trials blended in drinking glasses; no equipment purchased at all.	500
Year two	Additional notes and new accords, dyes, semi-professional equipment, proper bottles, and 100% rectified alcohol.	1,300
Total spent before any revenue existed		**1,800**

THE FORTY-DAY CYCLE

A composition cannot be judged on the day it is mixed. What it smells like in the glass and what it smells like on skin a month later are different things, and the difference is where most formulations fail.

ONE TRIAL, START TO VERDICT

STAGE	DURATION	CONDITIONS
Blending	One session	By dropper, by hand, in small volume
Freezing	7 days	To settle and clarify the blend
Maceration	30 days	Darkness, steady 16–19°C
Total per serious trial	**40 days**	**Before it can be assessed at all**

Thirty-plus formulations at forty days each would be over three years if they were run one after another, and only two were available. They were not run in sequence: batches overlapped, and the ones that failed obviously, the blend that burned the nose or sat oily in the glass, were killed at mixing rather than given a month of rooftop time they did not deserve.

HOW THEY FAILED

- **Too oily.** Pleasant in the glass, heavy and slick once it was on skin.
- **Burned the nose.** Sharp in a way that made it unwearable regardless of how it smelled.
- **No longevity.** Correct at first spray and gone before midday.
- **Already exists.** Technically fine and smelling like a dozen things already on the shelf, which for a niche house is the worst of the four.

THE ALCOHOL DECISION

Most perfumery, including the French houses, works at 96% rectified alcohol. Marcus Aurelius works at **100%**. A litre costs approximately ten times as much.

The remaining 4% in a 96% base is water, and water is not neutral in a composition: it affects how the oils sit together, how the top notes release, and how the whole thing ages in the bottle. Paying ten times for the last four percent is not a rational decision on a spreadsheet. It is a decision about what the company is willing to have its name on.

Anyone can buy the same oils tomorrow. Nobody can buy two years.

VISION & MISSION

VISION

For Marcus Aurelius to stand among the world's recognised niche fragrance houses. Not a regional brand, but one that competes internationally on quality, identity and presence.

MISSION

Every detail, no matter how small, is reviewed and refined before it reaches the public. Developing a single fragrance can take up to two years to get the notes exactly right; a single social media post can take four or five days to reach the intended look. Precision and patience are not a side detail here. They are the foundation of the work.

The mission is deliberately stated as a working practice rather than as an aspiration, because it is already how the company operates and can be checked against the record: two years of development, thirty rejected formulations, and a soft launch that ran privately rather than publicly because the photography was not finished.

CORE VALUES

Precision

Every detail is reviewed multiple times before release, without rushing. The forty-day trial cycle is this value expressed as a process rather than as a sentiment.

Authenticity

No imitation, no cutting corners. Every fragrance is an original blend, which is why thirty of them were thrown away rather than adjusted into something that already existed.

Exclusivity

Not for everyone, by design. Built for those who can carry a strong identity. This is the value that governs distribution, not only composition.

Patience over speed

Time is treated as an investment, not an obstacle. Two years before the first sale was a cost the company chose to pay rather than a delay it suffered.

Confidence & pride

The brand sells a feeling of distinction, and that feeling shows in every decision, from the oil in the bottle to the refusal to let anyone else stock it.

How these are tested

A value is only real if it has cost something. Each of these has: the alcohol decision, thirty discarded formulations, and turning down retail placement that would have moved volume.

OPERATIONS

Everything below is done by the company itself. There is no contract manufacturer, no filling line and no third party anywhere between the raw oil and the customer's hand. This is what small-batch actually means in practice rather than as a marketing word.

THE PRODUCTION SEQUENCE

FROM RAW MATERIAL TO A BOTTLE THAT CAN BE SOLD

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	TIME
Sourcing	Oils ordered from the European supplier through the Swiss intermediary. Lead time is the single largest external dependency in the business and the reason batches are planned months ahead rather than reactively.	Weeks
Weighing and blending	By dropper, by hand, in small volume against a written formula. No automation, because the volumes are too small for a machine to be more accurate than a careful hand.	One session
Alcohol addition	100% rectified alcohol, added to concentration. This is the step where the ten-times material cost is spent.	Same session
Freezing	Seven days. Settles the blend and drops out anything that will not stay in solution, so it can be separated rather than left to cloud the bottle later.	7 days
Maceration	Thirty days in darkness at a steady 16 to 19 degrees. The oils marry; the composition that comes out is not the one that went in, which is the entire reason the stage exists.	30 days
Filtration and filling	Clarified, then filled into the 100ml bottle, capped and sealed.	One session
Labelling and boxing	Label applied, bottle boxed with its packaging and bag, ready to ship.	One session
Total	**From blending to a sellable bottle**	**~40 days**

WHY THE TIMING CONSTRAINS THE BUSINESS

A forty-day cycle means the company cannot respond to demand within the month it appears. If fifty orders arrive in a week and stock is not already macerating, they cannot be filled in that week at any price. This is not a flaw to be engineered away; it is the same constraint every house that macerates properly lives with, and it is a large part of why limited batches are the honest description of the production model rather than a scarcity tactic.

It has two direct consequences for how the company is run. Production has to be planned against a forecast rather than an order book, which puts real weight on the market research in section 22. And pre-payment, as used for the limited numbered edition in section 12, is not a cash-flow trick: it is the only way to know how much to make of something that takes forty days before anyone has asked for it.

WHAT IS DELIBERATELY NOT OUTSOURCED, AND WHY

FUNCTION	HELD IN-HOUSE BECAUSE
Composition	It is the product. Everything else is packaging around it.
Blending and filling	Volumes are small enough that outsourcing would cost more per unit and add a party who can see the formula.
Maceration	Requires a stable cool dark space, which the rooftop provides at no cost.
Packaging design	Each fragrance has its own narrative; a generic supplier template would flatten four identities into one.
Photography and content	Four to five days per post is only possible when the person shooting knows what the fragrance is supposed to mean.
Selling	Section 09. This is the one that costs the most volume and is least negotiable.

PRODUCT SPECIFICATION

COMMON TO ALL FOUR FRAGRANCES

Format	Eau de Parfum
Volume	100ml
Alcohol base	100% rectified, against the 96% used by most perfumery including the French houses
Additives	None. No banned substances and no synthetic pheromone additives of any kind
Production	Small batch, hand-blended, 30-day maceration
Packaging	Bottle, themed outer box, branded bag, label
Loaded cost	**3.90 to 5.50 JOD per unit, everything included**

PACKAGING, PER FRAGRANCE

Each box carries the narrative of the fragrance inside it rather than a shared house template with a different colour. This is more expensive per unit than one design in four colourways, and it is the reason the collection reads as four objects rather than as one product line.

FRAGRANCE	PACKAGING THEME	WHERE IT COMES FROM
Maxima	Brand identity	The house mark, held plain, since it is the entry point to the collection
Maximus	Roman aqueduct	The engineering register: structure, repetition, water
Romeo di Roma	Venetian bell tower	The campanile, and with it the whole Venetian loggia vocabulary
Roma Juliette	The Romeo & Juliette narrative	The balcony, and the pairing that gives the two their names

THE DISCOVERY SET

Four fragrances at 10ml each, the full collection. Ten millilitres is deliberately not a sample vial: it is roughly a hundred sprays, enough to wear a fragrance for a week and find out how it behaves on the person wearing it rather than on a paper strip in a shop.

Its price is credited in full against the first 100ml bottle the customer buys, which makes it a trial that costs nothing if it works and a small paid product if it does not.

BUSINESS MODEL

Marcus Aurelius operates on a **Direct-to-Consumer** model, selling directly to customers through its own website and social channels, with no intermediaries. This preserves full control over the customer experience, from packaging to communication, and protects the exclusivity the brand is built on. Releases are produced in limited batches.

WHY NOBODY ELSE SELLS IT

The company does not wholesale, and does not intend to. This is the position most likely to be read as a limitation, so it is worth stating plainly why it is not one.

A shelf is a comparison. A bottle placed in someone else's shop stands next to another house's work, priced above it or below it. Whatever the customer concludes in that moment is a conclusion the company did not author and cannot correct. The composition took two years; the context it is judged in would take a stranger's shelf plan.

A shelf is also a duration. Stock that sits waits, and stock that waits collects dust. A customer who picks up a dusty bottle has learned something about the brand that is not true and cannot be argued with. There is no version of that encounter the company can recover from at a distance.

Retail, when it comes, will be ours. The expansion path is brand-owned boutiques, and the intention for them is not a shop but a room: a customer should feel they have walked into a Roman museum rather than a fragrance counter. That is not achievable in a metre of someone else's floor space, at any margin.

The fragrance is not the only thing being sold. The moment of encountering it is part of the product, and it cannot be subcontracted.

WHAT THE MODEL GIVES UP, AND WHAT IT BUYS

GIVEN UP	BOUGHT
Volume from third-party shelves and marketplaces	Every dinar of retail margin stays with the company
Passive discovery by shoppers browsing a perfumery	Complete authorship of how the brand is first met
Distributor relationships that would ease geographic expansion	No price erosion, no grey-market resale, no discounting by others
Faster scale in the first two years	An 87.9% gross margin at soft-launch pricing, rising to 93.9% at list

The trade is deliberate: this is a company that would rather sell fewer bottles at full authorship than more bottles it no longer controls.

UNIT ECONOMICS

Every figure in this section is real. Costs are fully loaded: oil, bottle, packaging, bags and label, per 100ml unit.

COST, PRICE AND MARGIN PER BOTTLE (JOD)

FRAGRANCE	COST	LIST PRICE	GROSS PROFIT	MARGIN
Romeo di Roma	5.50	90	84.50	93.9%
Roma Juliette	5.40	90	84.60	94.0%
Maximus	4.50	70	65.50	93.6%
Maxima	3.90	70	66.10	94.4%

WHAT THE COST FIGURES SHOW

The spread between the most and least expensive bottle to make is 1.60 JOD. That is a strategic fact rather than an accounting one: it means the collection could carry a single price across all four, which is what several established niche houses do precisely to signal that the collection rather than the individual product is the thing being sold. The current structure prices the two romantic compositions higher, which the oil content supports.

The oil itself is where the cost sits. The raw material for Romeo di Roma runs at 800 JOD per 100ml of neat oil and Roma Juliette at 650 JOD; only a few millilitres of it goes into a finished bottle, which is what brings the loaded cost down to five and a half dinars. Stated the other way round: the oil alone in Romeo di Roma is priced above a full bottle of most designer fragrance.

PRICING, AND THE SOFT LAUNCH

List prices are **90 JOD** for Romeo di Roma and Roma Juliette and **70 JOD** for Maximus and Maxima. The first two weeks of sales ran at exactly half those figures, 45 and 35, as a founding-circle price to friends and family.

> *This was a private round, not a public discount, and the distinction matters. A publicly advertised half-price launch anchors the market at the lower number permanently and teaches buyers to wait for the next one; a closed round at founder pricing does neither, because the market never saw it. The 45 and 35 figures appear in this document because it is a full disclosure of the record, and nowhere on the public site.*

BREAK-EVEN ON THE TWO YEARS

At an average loaded cost of 4.83 JOD and the soft-launch price mix actually achieved, each bottle contributed 34.17 JOD. Against 1,800 JOD of development spend:

36	68%	53
Bottles sold in the first two weeks	Of development recovered already	Bottles to clear it entirely

Seventeen more bottles at the same mix and the same founder pricing closes the whole two years. At list price the same threshold falls to twenty-five bottles in total.

REVENUE STREAMS

Three streams, all of them direct. Nothing is sold through a middleman, and nothing is discounted to move it.

01 DIRECT SALES · PRIMARY, ACTIVE

100ml Eau de Parfum, sold only from marcusscent.com.

No shop, no distributor, no reseller taking a cut. This is not a limitation being explained away: rent, retail markup and distribution margin are what normally consume the price of a fragrance. Removing all three is what allows the oil to be the expensive part, and it is the reason a bottle costing 5.50 to make can be sold at 90 without the buyer being exploited, because what they are paying for is the composition rather than the chain that carried it.

02 THE DISCOVERY SET · ACQUISITION, LAUNCHING

The full collection, four fragrances at 10ml each.

Ten millilitres is a size you can actually wear, not a vial. Nobody commits to a 100ml niche fragrance they have never smelled, and this answers that objection without ever quoting a lower price for a bottle: what the set costs is credited against the first full bottle the customer buys. The trial pays for itself, and a buyer who liked it arrives already paid up.

This is the mechanism that replaces discounting. It gives a reason to buy now without teaching anyone that the price is negotiable.

03 LIMITED NUMBERED EDITION · GROWTH, PLANNED

A fifth fragrance, made once. 100 numbered units at 300 JOD, reserved and paid before production.

Packaging will cost more than the oil, which is the intention: at this price the buyer should be holding the reason, not just wearing it. Payment at reservation funds the run, so nothing is manufactured on speculation and no capital sits in stock that has not sold.

One complete run is 30,000 JOD of revenue, which is roughly sixteen times the entire development spend of the company to date and twenty-one times the first two weeks of trading. It is scheduled for the growth phase rather than the launch, because a jump from a 90 JOD list price to 300 requires the 90 to be established in the market first.

> *Deliberately excluded: wholesale, marketplace listings, and any form of third-party resale. Section 09 sets out why. Also excluded is any revenue-share projection, since every other figure in this document is measured rather than modelled and a split would be the only invented number in it.*

COMPETITIVE POSITION

The business idea in section 01 claims the market has a hole in the middle. This is that claim shown as prices rather than asserted as a sentence.

THE NICHE MARKET BY PRICE BAND

BAND	TYPICAL 100ML PRICE	WHO IS THERE	WHAT THE BUYER GETS
Established niche	$300–600+	Maison Francis Kurkdjian, Creed, Xerjoff, Amouage	Genuine composition, and the cost of a European house's overheads, distribution and retail network built into the price
Regional heritage	$80–250	Ajmal, Rasasi, Swiss Arabian	Strong oud tradition and real depth in that register, less oriented to the Western niche idiom
Marcus Aurelius	~$100–127 70–90 JOD	—	Composition developed over two years on full-price materials, sold with no distributor or retail markup in the price at all
Niche-styled budget	$20–60	Numerous, largely undifferentiated	The appearance of niche. Cheaper oil, shorter or no maceration, and a composition that usually references something that already sold

WHAT THE TABLE IS ACTUALLY SHOWING

The gap is not in quality alone; it is in the relationship between quality and price. A buyer at $300 is paying for the composition *and* for the chain that delivered it. A buyer at $40 is paying only for the chain, because there is very little composition in the bottle. There is no established position where the buyer pays for the composition and nothing else.

That position is only reachable by a company that has removed the chain, which is what section 07 describes. The direct-to-consumer decision is therefore not a cost-saving measure that happens to be convenient. **It is the mechanism that makes the market position possible at all.** Without it, the same bottle would have to be priced into one of the two existing bands.

HONEST DISADVANTAGES AGAINST EACH BAND

AGAINST	WHERE MARCUS AURELIUS IS GENUINELY BEHIND
Established niche	No name recognition, no decades of archive, no physical presence in the cities where this buyer shops. A first-time buyer has only the website to judge by.
Regional heritage	No distribution, no shelf presence, and none of the trust that comes from a family name a customer's parents already bought.
Budget niche	Cannot compete on price and will never try. Also cannot match their speed to market, because forty days is forty days.

All three disadvantages share a cause: the company is two years old and has sold thirty-six bottles. Two of the three are solved only by time, and the plan in section 17 is built around that rather than around pretending otherwise.

PRICING PHILOSOPHY

List prices are 90 JOD for the romantic pair and 70 JOD for the kinetic pair. Neither number was reached by adding a margin to a cost.

COST DOES NOT SET THE PRICE HERE

A bottle costs between 3.90 and 5.50 JOD to make. A conventional retail multiple of three or four would price the collection between 12 and 22 JOD, which would place it squarely in the budget-niche band described in section 11, alongside exactly the products this company exists to be distinguishable from.

The cost figure is therefore not an input to the price. It is an input to the *margin*, which is what allows the company to survive on thirty-six bottles a fortnight instead of needing three hundred.

WHAT DOES SET IT

- **The band the composition belongs in.** A two-year composition on full-price oils belongs above the budget tier and below the European houses, because it has the first thing and not the second.
- **What the buyer is asked to believe.** A price is a claim about the object. At 20 JOD the claim is that this is an affordable alternative; at 90 the claim is that the contents justify it. The second claim is the true one, so the price has to make it.
- **The 20 JOD spread between the pairs.** Romeo di Roma and Roma Juliette carry heavier oil loads and more expensive raw material; the spread is small enough to read as a considered difference rather than as two separate products.

WHY NOTHING IS EVER DISCOUNTED

Discounting is the clearest behavioural marker separating a designer brand from a niche house. Designer fragrance discounts constantly; niche houses essentially never do. A customer who has seen a price fall learns two things at once: that the real price is the lower one, and that waiting is rewarded. Neither can be unlearned.

The company has one mechanism that does the work a discount would do without carrying its cost, and that is the discovery set: the price of the trial is credited against the first bottle. The customer gets value, the bottle price is never quoted lower, and the person who arrives has already paid something and already knows they like it.

A discount is a sentence about the product that the company did not intend to say, and cannot take back.

THE SOFT LAUNCH, STATED PLAINLY

The first thirty-six bottles sold at 45 and 35 JOD, exactly half list, to friends and family. This document discloses that because it is a full record; the public site does not, and should not.

The distinction is not cosmetic. A private round at founder pricing is invisible to the market, so it sets no anchor. A public half-price launch would have set the anchor permanently, and the 90 JOD price would have spent the rest of its life being read as a 45 JOD product with a markup.

THE CUSTOMER JOURNEY

With no shop, no shelf and no advertising, every stage of this has to be built deliberately, because none of it happens by accident.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT IT COSTS THE COMPANY
Discovery	Instagram content, or a person wearing it being asked what it is. The second is the channel that produced the first thirty-six sales.	Four to five days per post. No ad spend.
Interest	The website, which has to do the work a shop assistant and a tester strip would do in a perfumery. This is why the site carries the founding story and the composition detail rather than only product cards.	Custom build rather than a template.
Objection	Nobody buys a 100ml niche fragrance unsmelled. This is the single largest barrier in the entire model and the reason the discovery set exists.	The set is sold near cost and credited back.
Trial	Four 10ml bottles, worn for real over days rather than sprayed on paper in a shop.	Product given away in all but name if they buy.
Purchase	Direct from marcusscent.com. The set price comes off the bottle.	Nothing to a distributor. Every dinar of margin retained.
Unboxing	Where the physical identity takes over from the digital one: tan and bronze, the themed box, the weight of the thing. Section 25 explains why the palette changes here.	Per-fragrance packaging rather than one design in four colours.
Return	Either another fragrance from the collection, having already tried all four, or the limited numbered edition when it opens for reservation.	—

THE ONE STAGE THAT IS BOUGHT RATHER THAN EARNED

Every stage above is paid for in time except the trial, which is paid for in product. That is deliberate: the discovery set is the only place in the model where the company spends real margin to remove a barrier, and it is spent at exactly the point where the barrier is highest.

The alternative solutions to the same problem are all worse. Free samples train people to collect samples. Discounting the bottle damages the price permanently. A returns policy invites a used bottle back. Selling a wearable trial and crediting it is the only version where the customer risks nothing and the company gives up nothing it cannot recover on the next purchase.

TRACTION: THE FIRST TWO WEEKS

A private soft launch at founding-circle pricing, before any public marketing existed and before the final photography was finished. No advertising spend of any kind.

FIRST FOURTEEN DAYS, BY FRAGRANCE (JOD)

FRAGRANCE	UNITS	PRICE	REVENUE	COST	GROSS PROFIT
Maximus	13	35	455	58.50	396.50
Maxima	9	35	315	35.10	279.90
Romeo di Roma	8	45	360	44.00	316.00
Roma Juliette	6	45	270	32.40	237.60
Total	**36**	—	**1,400**	**170.00**	**1,230.00**

36	1,400	87.9%	0
Bottles sold	JOD revenue	Gross margin	JOD spent on marketing

THREE THINGS THESE NUMBERS SAY

Development paid for itself before the launch did

The 1,230 JOD of gross profit covers 68% of two years of development in fourteen days. Seventeen more bottles at the same mix closes the remainder entirely.

The first SMART goal is nearly met before its clock started

Section 16 sets a target of the first fifty sales within three months of launch. Thirty-six arrived in two weeks, which is 72% of the goal in roughly 15% of the time, through a closed circle and with nothing spent on reaching anyone.

The sales mix confirms the seasonality independently

Maximus and Maxima, the two fresher compositions, accounted for twenty-two of thirty-six bottles: 61% of units, during summer. That is not a marketing assumption carried over from the market research, it is the company's own sales data agreeing with it, and it is a genuine input into how the two pairs should be timed and promoted.

AT LIST PRICE

The same thirty-six bottles at the public list prices of 90 and 70 would have produced 2,800 JOD of revenue and 2,630 JOD of gross profit, a margin of 93.9%. That figure is the one that matters going forward, since the founding-circle round is closed and will not be repeated.

SMART GOALS

Four goals, each set against the five criteria in full. The status column is the position as of August 2026.

GOAL 01 · LAUNCH AND FIRST SALE

Specific	Launch the online store and complete the first real sale, including final photography, product assembly and activating the sales channels.
Measurable	One completed public transaction through marcusscent.com.
Achievable	The site is live and all four fragrances are production-ready; only photography remains.
Relevant	Nothing else in the plan can begin until the channel is open.
Time-bound	Within 6 months.
Status	**Private sales complete; public channel pending photography.**

GOAL 02 · MARKET RESEARCH

Specific	Complete competitor analysis, target customer behaviour study and a final pricing strategy.
Measurable	Three deliverables, finished and documented.
Achievable	Global, regional and local analysis is already drafted; see section 14.
Relevant	Pricing cannot be finalised without it, and pricing governs everything downstream.
Time-bound	Within 2 months, before going to market.
Status	**Substantially complete; pricing set at 90 and 70 JOD.**

GOAL 03 · AUDIENCE

Specific	Reach 1,000 engaged social media followers as a customer base ahead of launch.
Measurable	1,000 followers, measured on engagement rather than count alone.
Achievable	Content is already produced in-house at four to five days per post.
Relevant	Instagram is the only marketing channel the strategy uses.
Time-bound	Within 6 months.
Status	**In progress.**

GOAL 04 · FIRST FIFTY SALES

Specific	Achieve the first 50 sales as an early signal of market acceptance.
Measurable	50 units sold.
Achievable	36 were sold in the first two weeks through a closed circle alone.
Relevant	It is the threshold at which the two years of development are fully repaid.
Time-bound	Within 3 months of launch.
Status	**36 of 50 reached in two weeks.**

ACTION PLAN

PHASE 1 · SETUP · LARGELY COMPLETE

Brand identity, all four fragrances production-ready with finalised packaging, a live website at marcusscent.com built custom rather than on a template platform, and an active Instagram presence. Remaining: final photography and asset consolidation before official launch.

PHASE 2 · LAUNCH · NEXT 6 MONTHS

Complete market research in the first two months, officially open online sales, run a structured social campaign, and target the first fifty sales within three months of launch.

No third-party retail placement at any stage. The bottle is never sold by anyone else and never stands on a shelf beside another house's work. Section 09 sets out the reasoning; it applies from the first day of trading, not only at scale.

PHASE 3 · GROWTH · POST-VALIDATION

Expand through brand-owned boutiques only, each built as a full sensory environment rather than a retail counter. Expand the product line, beginning with the limited numbered edition. Build a dedicated marketing and logistics team. Explore limited-edition creative collaborations, on the strict condition that no collaboration results in the product being sold by a third party.

Every phase is constrained by the same rule: the company grows by owning more of the chain, never by handing pieces of it away.

GROWTH STRATEGY

Marketing

High-quality visual content on Instagram rather than broad paid advertising. Scarcity itself is the instrument: the waitlist, the limited editions and the brand's own line create curiosity instead of reach. The first two weeks produced 36 sales on zero marketing spend, which is the argument for this approach rather than a happy accident.

Partnerships

Selective, carefully chosen collaborations only: luxury and fashion-aligned voices for exposure. Never third-party resale of the product itself, under any partnership structure.

Technology

The custom-built site remains the sole direct sales channel. Investment goes into the site experience rather than into listing on third-party marketplaces, which would surrender the customer journey and the pricing at the same time.

Expansion

Vertical, not horizontal. Brand-owned boutiques only, each designed as a full sensory experience rather than a shelf display, with later geographic expansion, particularly the Gulf, following the same fully-owned model.

WHAT VERTICAL EXPANSION MEANS IN PRACTICE

Horizontal growth would mean the same bottle in more places: distributors, perfumeries, marketplaces. It is faster, and it is available now. Vertical growth means more of the experience under the company's own control: its own room, its own staff, its own lighting, its own account of what the brand is.

The intended boutique is closer to a Roman museum than a fragrance counter, and that is not decoration. It is the only format in which the two years in the bottle can be communicated at the moment of purchase rather than left to a shelf tag.

MARKET ANALYSIS

GLOBAL

The global perfume market is valued at roughly $60–70B in 2026. Within it, the niche fragrance segment is the fastest-growing category, projected to reach approximately $4.85B by 2026 and growing at around 9.1% annually against roughly 2.7% for the mass market. Consumer research shows about 62% of buyers prefer niche fragrances over mass-market products, and premium gifting accounts for nearly half of niche demand.

Key global competitors: Maison Francis Kurkdjian, Creed, Xerjoff, Amouage.

MENA AND REGIONAL

The Middle East perfume market is valued at roughly $4B in 2026 and is projected to grow at approximately 7.5% annually. Fragrance is deeply embedded in the region's culture and hospitality traditions, and regional fragrance sales are growing at roughly 11% annually, with oud-based compositions growing over 20% year on year.

Leading regional players: Ajmal, Rasasi, Swiss Arabian.

The opportunity lies in the gap between traditional oud-heavy fragrances and Western-style niche perfumes: a space Marcus Aurelius occupies directly through blends like Romeo di Roma, which puts saffron and vanilla against oud and leather rather than choosing one tradition.

JORDAN AND LOCAL

Jordan's fragrance market shows rising demand for scents rooted in regional identity, and Amman itself has a dense concentration of perfume retail. Local competitors range from budget domestic brands offering imitation scents to international niche distributors selling at premium import prices.

The gap: no locally designed and produced brand currently competes at true international niche quality and identity. That is precisely the space this company was built to occupy, and the reason the oil sourcing runs through Europe rather than locally.

RISK ANALYSIS

Every risk below is real and most of them are structural: they follow directly from decisions this document defends elsewhere. A plan that lists only risks it has already solved is not a risk analysis.

OPERATIONAL AND SUPPLY

RISK	CONSEQUENCE	RESPONSE
Single supply source	One European supplier reached through one intermediary. A price change, an export restriction or a lost relationship affects all four fragrances at once.	The most serious risk the company carries. A second qualified source is the correct answer and has not been secured yet; until it is, larger raw-material orders held in stock are the partial cover.
Forty-day lead time	Demand cannot be met inside the month it appears. A successful campaign could produce orders that cannot be filled.	Forecast-led production, and pre-payment on limited editions so quantity is known before the clock starts.
Single point of production	One person, one rooftop. Illness, a move, or losing access to the space stops production entirely.	Acknowledged and currently uncovered. The Phase 3 logistics hire in section 17 is the first structural answer to it.
Batch failure	A macerated batch that comes out wrong costs forty days and the materials.	Written formulas and consistent conditions; the failure modes are known from thirty rejected trials rather than unknown.

MARKET AND COMMERCIAL

RISK	CONSEQUENCE	RESPONSE
No third-party distribution	Growth is capped by the reach of one Instagram account and word of mouth. This is by far the largest commercial risk in the document.	Accepted deliberately, for the reasons in section 09. The mitigation is not distribution but owned retail, which is slower and more expensive and is the trade the company has chosen.
Concentration in one channel	An Instagram account is not owned. Losing it removes the entire discovery layer overnight.	The website and the customer list are owned; building the list rather than the follower count is the correct emphasis and is under-weighted at present.
Unsmelled purchase	The core objection in the whole model. Online-only means nobody can try before buying.	The discovery set, section 14. This is the mitigation the business is built around.
Price scepticism	90 JOD from an unknown Jordanian house is a harder claim than 90 JOD from a French one.	Transparency about what is in the bottle: the two years, the alcohol, the refusal of cheap oil. This document is part of that answer.
Imitation	A successful composition invites copying, and the budget tier copies quickly.	The formula can be approximated; the two years, the maceration discipline and the identity cannot. Copies will exist and will be cheaper, which is the market condition described in section 01 rather than a new problem.

FINANCIAL

RISK	CONSEQUENCE	RESPONSE
Self-funded	1,800 JOD of development came from the founders. There is no runway beyond what sales generate.	The margin structure is the cover: at 93.9% list margin, low volume is survivable in a way it would not be at retail margins.
Inventory tied up	Bottles made and unsold are cash sitting on a shelf.	Small batches, and pre-payment on the limited edition so that run is funded before it is produced.
Raw material price	Oil at 650–800 JOD per 100ml is exposed to currency and commodity movement.	Loaded cost is under 6 JOD against a 70–90 JOD price, so even a large input rise is absorbable without touching the price. This is the practical value of the margin.

BUILDING SOMETHING THAT LASTS

Sustainability here is meant in both senses: a business that can keep running, and one that is defensible in how it runs.

ENVIRONMENTAL

- **Made to order in small batches.** The most environmentally expensive thing a fragrance company does is manufacture stock that is never sold. Small-batch production against forecast, with pre-payment on limited editions, means very little is made that nobody wanted.
- **No maceration equipment.** The thirty-day stage runs on the ambient temperature of a rooftop rather than on a climate-controlled room. The energy cost of the slowest stage in the process is zero.
- **No distribution network.** Direct shipping from one place to the customer removes the warehouse-to-distributor-to-retailer legs entirely, along with everything unsold that would eventually travel back.
- **100ml as the only size.** One bottle, one box, rather than a range of sizes each with its own tooling and packaging run.

> *Stated honestly: none of this was designed as environmental policy. It is what a small, careful, direct company does anyway. It is included because it is true, not because it was the intention.*

ETHICAL

- **No banned or synthetic pheromone additives.** The category is full of products making implied claims about attraction through additives that are either restricted or inert. This company competes on composition and says so.
- **No imitation.** Every composition is original. The budget tier's business model is to smell like something expensive; this one's is not.
- **Honest pricing.** No inflated list price that exists only to be discounted from, and no permanent sale. The price on the site is the price.
- **Materials paid for properly.** The refusal to prove formulas on cheap oil, and the ten-times cost of 100% alcohol, are both decisions to pay full price for the thing the customer is told they are buying.

COMMERCIAL DURABILITY

A business that needs volume to survive is fragile at low volume. This one does not. At a 93.9% gross margin, the entire two-year development cost is repaid by twenty-five bottles at list price, and the company has no rent, no staff, no distributor and no marketing budget to carry between sales.

That is the real sustainability argument: the cost base is small enough that the company can afford to grow slowly, and growing slowly is what protects everything else in this document.

The company is built so that patience is affordable. Every other commitment in it depends on that being true.

FINANCIAL OUTLOOK

Built from the real figures in sections 10 and 15 rather than from a growth assumption. Each scenario states what would have to be true for it to happen.

ANNUAL GROSS PROFIT AT LIST PRICING, BY VOLUME

SCENARIO	BOTTLES / YEAR	REVENUE	COGS	GROSS PROFIT
Current run-rate continued	936	72,800	4,420	68,380
Half the current rate	468	36,400	2,210	34,190
First-year target	200	15,560	966	14,594
Plus one limited edition run	**+100**	**+30,000**	—	—

> *The first row extrapolates thirty-six bottles a fortnight across a year, which is shown because it is the observed rate and not because it is expected to hold. It came from a closed circle of friends and family, which is finite by definition and is now exhausted. It is included as the ceiling of what has actually been demonstrated, not as a forecast.*

WHAT THE MIDDLE ROW ASSUMES

Four hundred and sixty-eight bottles a year is nine a week. It requires the public launch to perform at roughly half the rate a private circle did, sustained, with the discovery set carrying the conversion and Instagram carrying the discovery. It is not obviously achievable and it is not obviously out of reach, which is what makes it the useful number to plan against.

COST STRUCTURE

LINE	NOW	AFTER PHASE 3
Rent	None. Rooftop.	Boutique lease, the single largest new cost
Staff	None	Marketing and logistics, per the action plan
Marketing	0 JOD. Content is made in-house	Unchanged in kind; the strategy does not add paid advertising
Distribution	None, permanently	None, permanently
Materials	3.90–5.50 per unit	Lower per unit at larger order volumes

The company currently has almost no fixed costs at all, which is why 1,400 JOD of revenue in a fortnight left 1,230 JOD of it as profit. Phase 3 is the point at which that stops being true, and it is deliberately placed after validation rather than before it.

PRODUCTS

Four fragrances, four narratives, each produced in limited batches. The collection is built as two pairs, and each pair carries its own register inside the shared house identity.

MAXIMA · FOR HER · KINETIC PAIR

Top	Red berries, bergamot, sweet almond
Heart	Jasmine, rose, caramel
Base	Vanilla, white musk, woods
Benefits	Long-lasting wear, everyday luxury without heaviness, a distinct identity that sets it apart from mainstream perfumes.
Deliverables	100ml bottle, brand-identity packaging, small-batch production.
Economics	**Cost 3.90 JOD · list 70 JOD · margin 94.4%**

MAXIMUS · FOR HIM · KINETIC PAIR

Top	Orange, bergamot, lemon zest, sea breeze
Heart	Grapefruit, pink pepper, cedarwood, jasmine
Base	Leather, ambergris, sandalwood, white musk
Benefits	A balance of freshness and strength, strong presence without being overpowering, excellent longevity from the leather-amber base.
Deliverables	100ml bottle, Roman-aqueduct-themed packaging, small-batch production.
Economics	**Cost 4.50 JOD · list 70 JOD · margin 93.6% · best seller, 13 of the first 36**

ROMEO DI ROMA · UNISEX, LEANING MASCULINE · ROMANTIC PAIR

Top	Vanilla, saffron, pineapple
Heart	Leather, patchouli, caramel
Base	Oud, sandalwood, musk
Benefits	A rare pairing of saffron and vanilla against oud and leather: heavy and sensual without any banned additives, distinct from anything else on the market.
Deliverables	100ml bottle, Venetian-bell-tower-themed packaging, small-batch production.
Economics	**Cost 5.50 JOD · list 90 JOD · margin 93.9% · the first fragrance completed**

ROMA JULIETTE · FOR HER · ROMANTIC PAIR

Top	Saffron, jasmine, bergamot, mandarin, orange
Heart	Tuberose, red fruits, rose, caramel, almond
Base	Vanilla, tonka bean, white musk, amberwood, sandalwood
Benefits	The most complex and layered composition of the four, classic Italian opulence, exceptional longevity.
Deliverables	100ml bottle, packaging themed around the Romeo & Juliette narrative, small-batch production.
Economics	**Cost 5.40 JOD · list 90 JOD · margin 94.0%**

FIFTH, PLANNED

A limited numbered edition, made once, in a run of one hundred at 300 JOD, reserved and paid before production. Composition not yet fixed. See section 12.

THINKING METHOD

Six stages, each shown with what it actually produced in this company rather than what it means in the abstract.

01 DISCOVER

Identifying the real gap in the market: the space between overpriced originality and cheap imitation.

In practice: the founding question was not a business question at all. It was why no fragrance carried a particular set of notes. The market gap was found by wanting something that did not exist, then discovering that the reason it did not exist was structural.

02 DEFINE

Defining the identity of each fragrance beyond a nice smell: a persona, a story, a place.

In practice: Romeo di Roma and Roma Juliette are not two variants of one accord; they are two characters, and the packaging, the register and the colour treatment follow from that rather than from a colour system applied afterwards.

03 DESIGN

Designing the scent composition and the visual identity together, so neither feels separate from the other.

In practice: Maximus was photographed in water among lemon slices, and its visual register on the site is a beach-chair stripe. Romeo di Roma was photographed bound in rope and its register is a Venetian loggia. The image and the composition were decided as one thing.

04 DEVELOP

Up to two years of iterative formula development to get every note exactly right.

In practice: more than thirty formulations, each serious one requiring forty days before it could even be judged, and 1,800 JOD spent before a single sale. Four survived.

05 DEPLOY

A careful, unrushed launch. Nothing reaches the public before it has been reviewed and refined.

In practice: the launch is still private. Thirty-six bottles have sold to a closed circle while the public opening waits on photography that is not finished. The revenue was available; the standard was not met yet.

06 OPTIMIZE

Continuous refinement, down to how long a single social media post takes to get right: four to five days.

In practice: the specialists' advice to prove formulas on cheap oil first was refused, because optimising against the wrong material optimises the wrong thing. The same logic governs the alcohol at ten times the price.

BRAND IDENTITY

DIGITAL IDENTITY

Black background, cream text, muted gold accents, used for the website, social media and all online communication. Chosen to convey strength and quiet confidence without visual noise. The fragrance does not need loud colours to prove itself.

SWATCH	HEX	ROLE
Ink	#100E0B	Ground, everywhere
Cream	#F5F0E8	Primary reading colour
Gold	#C9A25C	Accent, headings, figures

PHYSICAL IDENTITY

Tan and bronze tones on packaging and labels, chosen to evoke the warmth of Roman stone, marble and aged bronze: a different emotional register for the moment the customer physically holds the product.

SWATCH	HEX	ROLE
Tan	#CBB08A	Packaging ground
Bronze	#8A6A3C	Label and edge detail
Gilt	#E0C48D	Highlight

WHY TWO PALETTES RATHER THAN ONE

The dual system exists because a brand and a product live in two different moments. Black and gold carry the digital first impression: a screen glanced at in seconds, where restraint and contrast do the work of standing out. Tan and bronze carry the physical unboxing: a slower, tactile experience where warmth and texture matter more than contrast. Neither palette is decorative; each is matched to how the customer is actually encountering the brand at that instant.

COLLECTION REGISTERS

Maximus and Maxima are the energetic pair: youth, motion and confident wildness. Romeo di Roma and Roma Juliette are the romantic pair: stillness, depth and restrained power. This is the same principle established houses use when a sub-collection is given its own visual register while the house identity stays recognisable underneath.

On the website the register is not confined to a card. The page itself takes the colourway of whichever fragrance the reader is standing in front of, navigation and index rail included, and returns to the house black and gold between them, so the collection reads as a passage through four worlds rather than as four separate websites.

RECURRING MOTIFS

The bust mark, the Greek meander border and the classical-serif-plus-script pairing recur across every touchpoint, digital and physical alike, tying the two identities together.

WEBSITE STRATEGY

The company's actual digital presence, built custom rather than on a template platform like Shopify, for full control over the user experience. Since it is the sole sales channel, it is not a marketing asset that supports the business; it is the business.

PAGE	PURPOSE
Home	Video hero with direct routes to the Collection and the brand Story.
Shop / Collection	All four fragrances with SKU, pricing, and both product and lifestyle imagery.
Story	The founding narrative.
Atelier / Ingredients	Editorial content on ingredient philosophy and craftsmanship.
Founders	Personal introduction to the people behind the brand.
Contact & Order Tracking	Direct contact channel and order tracking.

WHY CUSTOM AND NOT A PLATFORM

A template platform would have been faster and cheaper, and it would have imposed a checkout, a product-card layout and a visual grammar shared with several million other shops. For a company whose entire position is that the encounter with the product is authored rather than generic, that is the one saving that could not be taken.

PORTFOLIO APPEARANCE & DESIGN

PALETTE, AND WHY THESE COLOURS

Black and gold on screen, tan and bronze in the hand, for the reasons set out in section 25. This document uses the digital palette because it is read on a screen, with the body text lifted well clear of the ground: a website can afford dim cream on ink because the reader is skimming, and a forty-page document cannot.

TYPOGRAPHY

FACE	ROLE	REASON
Cinzel	Display, wordmark and headings	A Roman inscriptional capital, cut for stone. The brand is named after a Roman emperor.
Playfair Display Italic	Script accent, flourishes	Carries the Italian register without tipping into calligraphy.
EB Garamond	Body, long-form reading	An old-style book face; the only one of the three chosen for reading rather than for effect.

The classical serif wordmark and the script *Perfumes* pairing echo the brand's Italian, Roman-influenced aesthetic without leaning on cliché. The bust mark and the Greek meander border repeat quietly across every section, never shouting, always present, because exclusivity is communicated through consistency and restraint, not volume.

THE WEBSITE IS PUBLISHED IN THREE LANGUAGES

English, Arabic and Italian, switchable from the navigation. Arabic required its own typography rather than the house faces, since Cinzel, Playfair Display and EB Garamond carry no Arabic glyphs at all: Reem Kufi for display, because Kufi is the Arabic script cut for stone exactly as Cinzel is the Latin one; Amiri for reading, a revival of the Bulaq naskh and the nearest Arabic has to an old-style book face; Aref Ruqaa for the flourish.

ORGANISATION AND NAVIGATION

Seventeen numbered sections, indexed in a fixed rail on every screen and in a full contents overlay, so the reader always knows both where they are and what else exists. The numbering is Roman in all three languages, because it is structure rather than language.

GET IN TOUCH

Website

marcusscent.com

Instagram

@marcusscent

Email

info@marcusscent.com

Telephone

+962 78 124 3839

OPEN TO COLLABORATION

Retailers, photographers and creative partners who work the way this brand works are welcome to write. So is anyone who simply wants to know when the next batch is poured.

> *One condition, stated up front so it does not have to be negotiated later: no collaboration results in the product being sold by anyone other than the company. Everything else is open.*

The Mastermind Behind The Masterpiece

ABDULLAH AL-SALLAL

Marcus Aurelius Perfumes · Amman, Jordan · 2026

LESSONS

Written as they were actually learned, including the ones that were expensive.

THE SLOWEST STAGE CANNOT BE SHORTENED, SO PLAN AROUND IT INSTEAD

Forty days is forty days. Every instinct at the start was to find a way to judge a blend faster, and there is not one: what a composition smells like on the day it is mixed says almost nothing about what it becomes. The productive response was to stop trying to compress the cycle and start running batches in parallel, and to kill the obvious failures at the mixing bench so that only serious candidates ever occupied a month of rooftop time.

TESTING ON THE WRONG MATERIAL TESTS THE WRONG THING

The advice to prove formulas on cheap oil and buy the good material afterwards was sensible, widely given, and wrong for this product. The same note from a cheaper source is a different composition made a different way. A formula that worked on cheap oil would have had to be re-proved on the real one, which is not a saving, it is the same work done twice with a false result in the middle.

MOST FAILURES WERE NOT TECHNICAL

Of the thirty-plus rejected formulations, the ones that burned the nose or sat oily were straightforward: something was wrong and it could be fixed. The hardest category to accept was the blend that was technically fine and smelled like everything already on the shelf. Nothing was broken. It simply had no reason to exist, and for a niche house that is the worst failure of the four, because it is the one that would still have sold.

THE FIRST CUSTOMERS CAME FROM WEARING IT, NOT FROM MARKETING

Thirty-six bottles sold with nothing spent on reaching anyone. The channel was a person wearing the fragrance in public and being asked what it was. That is not a scalable acquisition strategy and it was never intended as one, but it settled a question that no amount of research could: people who had not been told anything about the brand reacted to the product itself.

SAYING NO TO DISTRIBUTION IS EASY TO DECIDE AND HARD TO HOLD

The decision that no third party will ever sell the bottle is easy to write down and costs something every month it is kept. It has already cost the placement partnerships that were originally written into Phase 2 of the action plan, which were removed from this document rather than left in as a contradiction. Whether it stays intact under real growth pressure is genuinely untested.

A BRAND IS WHAT YOU REFUSE

Almost everything distinctive about this company is a refusal: no cheap oil, no 96% alcohol, no discounting, no marketplaces, no third-party shelves, no synthetic additives, no rushing a launch that is not photographed yet. The compositions matter, but they are four objects. The refusals are what make them a house.

GLOSSARY

Fragrance has its own vocabulary, and several of the terms in this document mean something more specific than they appear to.

Eau de Parfum (EDP)	A concentration band, typically 15–20% fragrance oil in alcohol. Higher than Eau de Toilette, lower than pure parfum. All four compositions here are EDP.
Niche	A house that composes for its own reasons rather than to a mass-market brief, usually in small volume and without licensing its name. Used as a description of practice here, not as a price band.
Designer fragrance	Fragrance sold under a fashion house's name, generally produced under licence by a large manufacturer, in high volume and widely discounted.
Top, heart, base	The three stages of how a composition unfolds. Top notes are what you smell in the first minutes; the heart emerges over the following hour; the base is what remains hours later and determines what the fragrance is remembered as.
Accord	Several materials blended so they read as one smell rather than as their parts.
Maceration	Resting a finished blend so the materials marry. Thirty days in darkness at a steady 16–19°C here. Skipping or shortening it is the most common corner cut in cheap production, because it is invisible in the bottle and obvious on skin.
Rectified alcohol	Alcohol purified by repeated distillation. Most perfumery uses 96%; the remaining 4% is water. This company uses 100%, at roughly ten times the cost per litre.
Longevity	How long a fragrance remains detectable on skin. Largely determined by the base and by the quality of the materials rather than by concentration alone.
Sillage	The trail a fragrance leaves in the air behind the wearer, as distinct from how long it lasts on the skin.
Oud	Resinous heartwood, central to Middle Eastern perfumery and among the most expensive raw materials in the field. The base of Romeo di Roma.
Small batch	Production in quantities small enough to be blended by hand in a single session. A description of method here rather than a marketing term.
Discovery set	A set of small wearable sizes of a full collection, sold to let a customer try before committing to a full bottle. 4 × 10ml here, credited against the first bottle.
D2C	Direct-to-consumer. The company sells to the person who will use the product, with no intermediary of any kind.
Loaded cost	The full per-unit cost including oil, alcohol, bottle, box, bag and label, rather than the cost of the contents alone.
JOD	Jordanian dinar. Approximately 1 JOD to 1.41 USD.